

EVERYWHERE YOU LOOK, it's there. Hanging from shopfronts, littering the sidewalks, strategically hidden around our houses, filling our dump yards, etc. Plastics have permeated our lives like hardly anything else in modern society.

While plastics are used by all of us, most do not understand how seriously the material disrupts our fragile environment. And while awareness has definitely increased over the years, very little has been achieved in terms of eliminating or reducing its usage. Further, looking at how extensively plastics are used, a solution to the problems of overuse, disposal and recycling has largely eluded us.

It is in search of answers to these questions like these that Harsh Mariwala, Chairman of fast-moving consumer goods company Marico, established a not-for-profit entity called Marico Innovation Foundation (MIF) in 2003 to explore the avenues where the group could support viable solutions.

"I realised the need to solve this challenge," says Mariwala. "The team [at MIF] did a deep dive in areas such as land and water pollution. It was apparent that plastic was ripe for an intervention, since there were major innovations emerging in the space, with a clear need for an ecosystem to be built around it."

Mariwala was of the view that most of the research that had been done focussed only on the problems around plastics, and not enough on viable solutions. "The ecosystem was looking for solutions across the value chain and that included recycling, sorting and collection. There was also a gap in knowledge on what one should focus on," Mariwala explains. That led MIF to prepare a report, as "the first step to create a knowledge book on plastics that offers innovative solutions".

To that end, the foundation partnered with the Indian Institute of Science (IISc) and management consulting firm Praxis Global Alliance as knowledge partners to prepare a report titled, "Innovation in Plastics: The Potential and Possibilities". The report, along with highlighting the key aspects of the plastics value chain such as the dramatic rise in plastic consumption in India (from 13.7 million tonnes in 2016-17 to 19.8 MT in 2019-20) and how plastic is currently recycled in India, also offers concrete measures around how a circular economy in plastics can be created. Not surprisingly, the report finds it to be a complex issue with many dimensions that need to be addressed with urgency.

Explaining the salient points of the report, Mariwala says that governments across the world have provided incentives to create circularity in the plastics ecosystem through less taxes, more infrastructure investments or equity grants to start-ups. "Besides, governments have also levied penalties, such as landfill tax and enforced the use of recycled plastics to a certain extent, in consumer products.

PLASTIC

PET (POLYETHYLENE TEREPHTHALATE)

Snack trays, fresh vegetable domes, FMCG containers, bottles



HDPE (HIGH DENSITY POLYETHYLENE)

Juice bottles, detergent bottles, toiletries



LDPE (LOW DENSITY POLYETHYLENE)

Cling wrap, shrink wrap, garbage bags

